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The Struggle and After[1]

FRIENDS—Allow me to congratulate you on your decision to summon a Political Conference of Indians abroad at a most critical time in the history of our country. It was so good of you to invite me to preside over the deliberations of this Conference—the Third Indian Political Conference—and I thank you most sincerely for the honour you have done me

We had been engaged in a non-violent war with the British Government—for the attainment of our political freedom. But to-day our condition is analogous to that of an army that has suddenly surrendered unconditionally to the enemy in the midst of a protracted and strenuous campaign. And the surrender has taken place, not because the nation demanded it—not because the national army rose in revolt against its leaders and refused to fight—not because the supply of the sinews of war was cut off—but either because the Commander-in-Chief was exhausted as a result of repeated fasting or because his mind and judgment were clouded owing to subjective causes which it is impossible for an outsider to understand.

What would have happened—I ask—if a similar incident had taken place in any other country? What happened to all the Governments that surrendered to the enemy at the end of the Great War? But India is a strange land.

The surrender of 1933 reminds one of the Bardoli Retreat of 1922. But in 1922, some explanation, however unsatisfactory, could be offered to justify the retreat. The outbreak of violence at Chauri Chaura was suggested as the pretext for suspending the Civil disobedience campaign in 1922. What explanation or pretext can one suggest to account for the surrender of 1933?

[1] The Presidential Speech of Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose at the third Indian Political Conference held in London on June 10, 1933.